

Green Knights

Children from elite schools take matters into their own hands, spending weekends cleaning up the Kolkata boulevard and removing 9,471 kg of trash



SOVASHIS MULLICK

CHILDREN FILL UP SACKS WITH GARBAGE

By Elora Sen

Shivansh Chandak spends his weekend mornings removing trash from the neighbourhood greens. He is not a ragpicker but a five-year-old student of La Martiniere for Boys. For company he has his 10-year-old brother Devansh. Both are part of a group of children in south Kolkata who have taken up a task which ideally should have been tackled by the Kolkata Municipal Corporation (KMC). The children are cleaning Southern Avenue, Kolkata's last surviving boulevard next to the Rabindra Sarovar lakes.

They have already collected 9,471 kg of trash, including bottles, combs, gutka pouches, cigarette packets and polyurethane strips, since their drive began in February. Armed with gloves and jute sacks, the children have turned cleaning into almost a game. Arman Sood, Class XII student of St. James', and the driving force behind the project has successfully motivated children from affluent south Kolkata neighbourhoods and elite schools. Shivang Churiwala, the president of the nature club of La Martiniere for Boys, says enthusiastically: "We may take up such projects in other areas of the city also."

Kaamila Pathreya from La Martiniere for Girls spends her weekend mornings along with Avni Agarwal and Riona Sen from Loreto House packing her sack with trash. They are joined in their cleanliness campaign by students from Modern High and Ashok Hall. "This has motivated me to even keep my room clean at home," says Sen with a smile. Kaamila's father Mudar says: "We normally get more than 25 volunteers and it is great what they do." The cleanliness drive has gained momentum with schools pitching in from across the city.

The campaign was started by Mudar after he spotted a heap of plastic bags in front of the Safari Park under a sign, 'Plastic is Banned'. "It was outrageous and I found the response of the children most enthusiastic," he said. Taking notice of their efforts, the KMC has now started sending vans to pick up the collected waste. Morning walkers stop by to praise the children while a local businessman has provided them with jute sacks. A curious passerby in fact mistook the scene for a film shoot. Though not a film shoot, but certainly a good shot by children for a cleaner and a greener city. ■